were thwarted in this goal: the following year, once again the death of the great khan obliged Hulegu and a large proportion of his army to return to Mongolia. The remnants of his forces were defeated by the Mamluks, commanded by Baibars, at Ain Jalut – the only occasion when the Mongols were decisively beaten in battle.

MONGOLS IN CHINA

In China the Mongol style of warfare eventually underwent an almost total transformation. From 1260 Genghis's descendant Kublai Khan, ruling from Beijing, launched a war of conquest against the Song dynasty that still controlled southern China. His army employed sophisticated Chinese weaponry, ranging from powerful crossbows, or ballistas, to varieties of gunpowder weapon, including bombs flung by catapults, primitive flame-throwers, and early antecedents of the handgun. The Mongols also learned from the Chinese how to conduct river and seaborne operations. Kublai's final victory over the Song, which made him undisputed emperor of China, was a naval battle fought in the South China Sea.

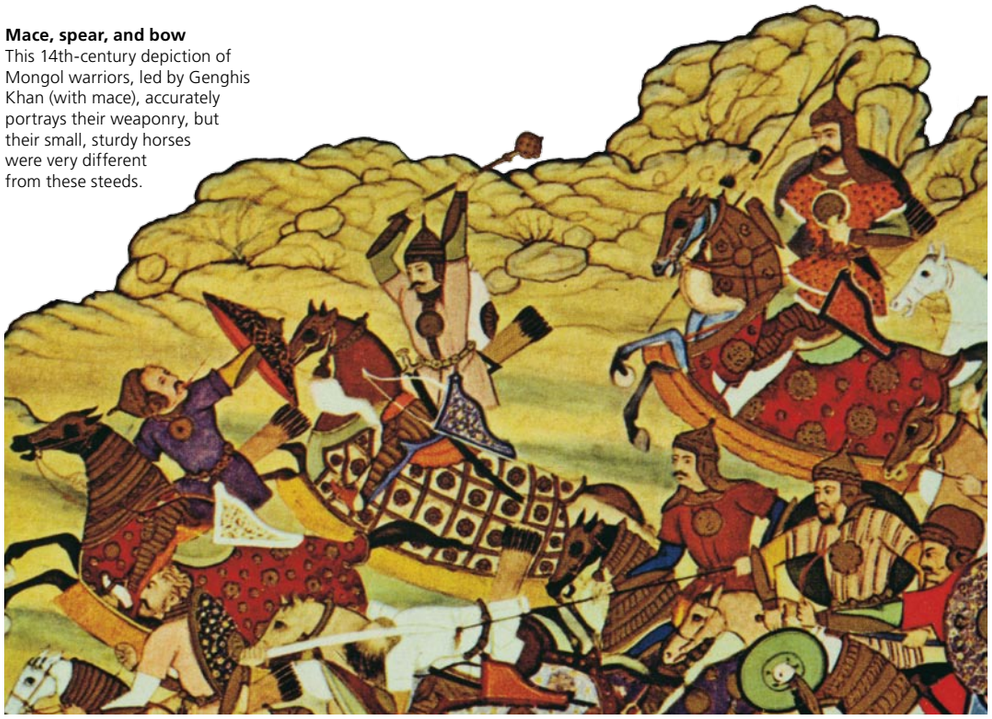
No doubt buoyed by this success, Kublai went on to attempt a seaborne invasion of Japan, which was launched from Korea. After a reconnaissance-in-force by a fleet of around 900 vessels in 1274, a full-scale invasion involving more than 4,000 warships was launched seven years later. The encounter with the Mongols was certainly a shock for the Japanese samurai, who had never experienced anything like their massed bowmen or gunpowder bombs. But a combination of stout Japanese resistance and a devastating typhoon made the Mongol expeditions costly failures.



The Mongol Empire
The Mongols ruled an area stretching from modern-day Korea to the eastern edge of Europe. By 1300 the Mongol territories were divided into four khanates: one centred on China; the Chagatai Khanate in central Asia; the Il-Khanate in Iran and Iraq; and the Khanate of the Golden Horde in Russia.

OLD HABITS

The Mongols remained essentially true to their roots. Even as Emperors of China, they continued to delight in hunting and value horsemanship above all other skills. They also never escaped from the bad habit of fighting each other over the succession to leadership. By the late 13th century Mongol rule extended from Russia to China and Korea, but this area was divided into four separate khanates. It was because they remained at heart steppe warriors that they could not found a durable empire. After Kublai's death in 1294, Mongol power went into rapid decline.



Mace, spear, and bow
This 14th-century depiction of Mongol warriors, led by Genghis Khan (with mace), accurately portrays their weaponry, but their small, sturdy horses were very different from these steeds.

MOBILITY AND FIREPOWER

The Mongol horsemen typically went into battle spread out in a dispersed formation. The majority of them were trained to fight as hit-and-run skirmishers. Their weapon was the composite bow, which existed in two versions: a light bow was shot from horseback, while a heavy bow was shot by a dismounted man. At the start of a battle the archers would advance to within range of the enemy and inflict a steady drain of losses by shooting arrows into their midst. At the same time they would avoid any efforts by the enemy to join battle, swiftly withdrawing in the face of counterattacks.

CUNNING WARRIORS

The Mongols delighted in battlefield trickery and would take pleasure in luring unwary opponents into a headlong pursuit by simulating flight, only to turn swiftly and trap their disorganized forces. When the enemy was at length worn down, frustrated and exhausted by the arrows of the skirmishers, the Mongols would bring in their elite armoured horsemen. Charging forward armed with lance, sword, and mace, they would engage the enemy at close quarters to finish them off. The horsemen on the wings of the Mongol line would by then have advanced at speed to complete an encirclement, leaving the enemy with no avenue of escape when the final attack was launched.